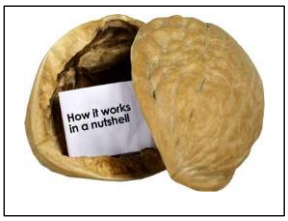
Title: Ozymandias by Percy Bysshe Shelley

The poem in a nutshell….



The narrator of Shelley's poem says he met a traveller from an "antique" (ancient) land and then tells us the story the traveller told him. The man had seen the remains of a huge statue in the desert. There were two enormous legs without a trunk and next to them lay a damaged "visage" (face). At the foot of the statue were words which reflected the arrogance and pride of Ozymandias. Those words seem very hollow now as the magnificent statue is destroyed and none of the pharaoh's works have lasted.

Context

- **Percy Bysshe Shelley** (1792-1822) is one of the most famous poets in all of English literature. He was one of a group of poets who became known as **The Romantics**. He came from a wealthy family, but was expelled from university for writing about atheism (not believing in God) which led to him to fall out with his father who disinherited him.
- Shelley was well known as a 'radical' during his lifetime and some people think *Ozymandias* reflects this side of his character. Although it is about the remains of a statue of Ozymandias (another name for the Egyptian pharaoh Rameses II) it can be read as a criticism of people or systems that become huge and believe themselves to be invincible.

3 Key Quotes

Quote	Method	What effect is created?
'king of kings'	Repetition / dramatic irony / juxtaposition	The repetition of 'kings' shows how arrogant Ozymandias was, yet when compared to the crumbling ruins of his statue, the poem undermines him and shows that he did not last forever as he thought he would.
'boundless and bare / The lone and level sands stretch far away.'	Alliteration	Alliteration is used three times in this quote, drawing attention to the words that show the ruin and destruction of time, and how even the mightiest of civilisations will eventually be forgotten and decay into dust.
'Nothing beside remains.'	Caesura	The caesura highlights to the reader how Ozymandias is no longer known and feared, despite his arrogance. The clear and blunt language perhaps also reveals how the narrator is unsympathetic towards the now long-gone ruler.

Aspects of Power or Conflict

- **Even the mightiest will fall**: Ozymandias thought his works would last forever and would be above everyone else's. Not true. Nothing is left intact and his own statue is in ruins.
- **You can't beat time**. Even a king dies and so will all the things he has built.
- **Pride comes before a fall**. Ozymandias' boasts about his own greatness seem very hollow now.
- **The power of art and words**. The only thing that does last is part of the statue and the powerful words on the inscription

Poems that can be linked

My Last Duchess

Tissue

PEAL Table: Cluster 6, Extract from *Tissue* and *Ozymandias*

	Point (AO1)	Evidence (AO1)	Analysis (AO2)	Link (AO3)
Tissue	The author of Tissue has used an extended metaphor to highlight how different forms of power can be. The author of Ozymandias, however, has used repetition to show how power can cause arrogance.	All of the references to paper through the poem, such as 'fine slips' and 'luminous scripts'.	Paper acts as a metaphor for life and the way we live it. It shows how paper can be so fragile yet be enormously powerful when it is used to convey information.	These poets both highlight power in these poems: the effects it can have on people and how power can last.
Ozymandias		'king of kings'	The repetition of 'kings' shows how arrogant Ozymandias was, yet when compared to the crumbling ruins of his statue, the poet undermines him and shows that he did not last forever as he thought he would.	
Tissue	Imtiaz Dharker has created enjambment to comment on time Percy Bysshe Shelley, on the other hand, has used a caesura	'see how easily / they fall away on a sigh'	The enjambment throughout the poem could show how time never stops and how it is impossible to properly keep track of things, with paper perhaps our best way of living on permanently. The fast pace could also create the effect of showing how difficult it is to keep track and organise our lives.	Both poets use structural techniques to reveal how changeable power and influence can be over time
Ozymandias		'Nothing beside remains.'	The caesura highlights to the reader how Ozymandias is no longer known and feared, despite his arrogance. The clear and blunt language perhaps also reveals how the narrator is unsympathetic towards the now long-gone ruler.	
Tissue	The author of tissue has used a simile to comment on power Whereas the author of Ozymandias has used alliteration	'might fly our lives like paper kites'	The simile suggests that our lives are not always in our control, but more like kites being blown by the wind. Connotations include a lack of control, but could be seen as a happy or childlike image.	The authors of both of these poems show the lack of control we have over the power of time
Ozymandias		'boundless and bare / The lone and level sands stretch far away.'	Alliteration is used three times in this quote, drawing attention to the words that show the ruin and destruction of time, and how even the mightiest of civilisations will eventually be forgotten and decay into dust.	